Stepping into Advanced Playing

Secure reading, efficient movement and purposeful practice.

How to use these notes

Read alongside the lessons or keep beside your piano. Review the explanations, try the practice tasks, then use the checklist without on-screen hints. Listening and demonstrations are available in the app. Notation examples show the opening two bars; full songs are in the Songbook.

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1. Your advanced starting point

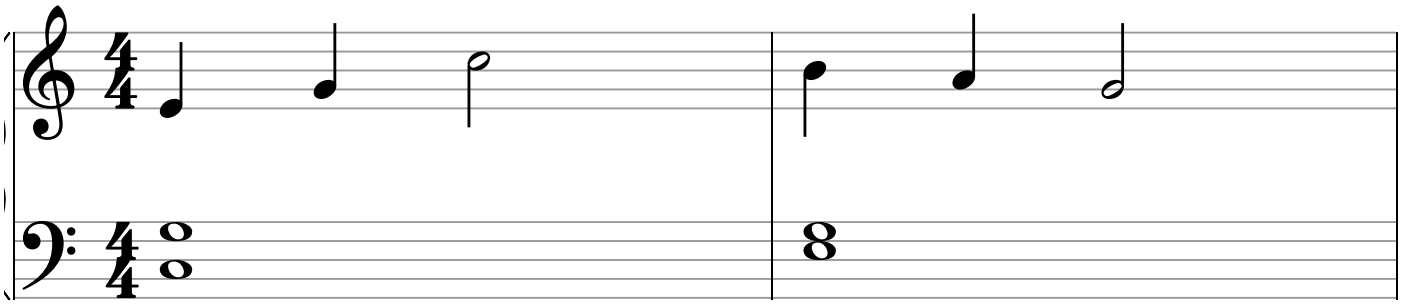
Assess reading, pulse, voicing and comfortable movement.

Your advanced starting point

Begin with a quiet, unhurried check. Read both staves, identify the key and meter, and silently prepare one bar. The melody should remain audible above the bass. Advanced study assumes comfortable intermediate reading, scales, chords and pedal changes. If either hand hesitates repeatedly, return to that intermediate skill while keeping this course available. Use an 88-key piano with a sustain pedal; start without pedal so it cannot hide gaps.

Practise · A balanced opening

Count four even beats. Make the right hand sing above a quiet left hand.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Read the bass before playing

Name the changing bass notes, then play the upper line without looking at lit keys.

Practise independently

Play once without hints, then describe the weakest element: reading, pulse, movement or balance. Choose one measurable practice goal, such as three calm entries into bar 2. Progress when the sound is controlled, not merely when the pitches register.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

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2. Diagnose before repeating

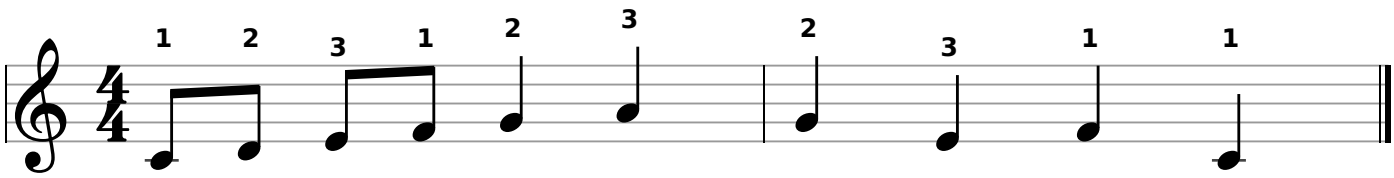
Choose a repair that addresses the cause of a mistake.

Diagnose before repeating

Repeated runs can rehearse the same hesitation. First name the cause: uncertain notes, a rhythm you cannot clap, an awkward fingering or a movement you have not prepared. Simplify only that part. For a leap, rehearse the silent landing. For a rhythm, clap and count. For a coordination problem, play the hands separately, then join one beat before and after the join.

Practise · Repair a crossing

Practise E-F with 3-1 twice, then reconnect the whole four-note group.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Repair the join

Start at the last two beats of the previous harmony. Keep the same pulse through the change.

Practise independently

Write a one-sentence diagnosis and a matching repair. After two successful slow attempts, play the complete phrase. If the error returns, shorten the repair rather than adding more full runs.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

3. Prepare a leap without reaching

Move toward a destination while releasing unnecessary tension.

Prepare a leap without reaching

A leap is a movement between places, not a large fixed hand shape. Look at the destination before leaving, release the old note and carry the forearm toward the new one. Begin with a generous rest. Remove the rest only after the landing is reliable. Keep the wrist mobile and the shoulder quiet; pain or persistent tension means stop and reassess the movement.

Practise · Right-hand destinations

Play, release, look and land. Do not keep the hand stretched across the octave.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Bass then chord

Use each rest to travel from the bass to a compact chord.

Practise independently

Rehearse the motion silently, then at a soft dynamic. Close the rest gradually while keeping the landing accurate. Never trade comfort for the metronome number.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

4. Hear three layers at once

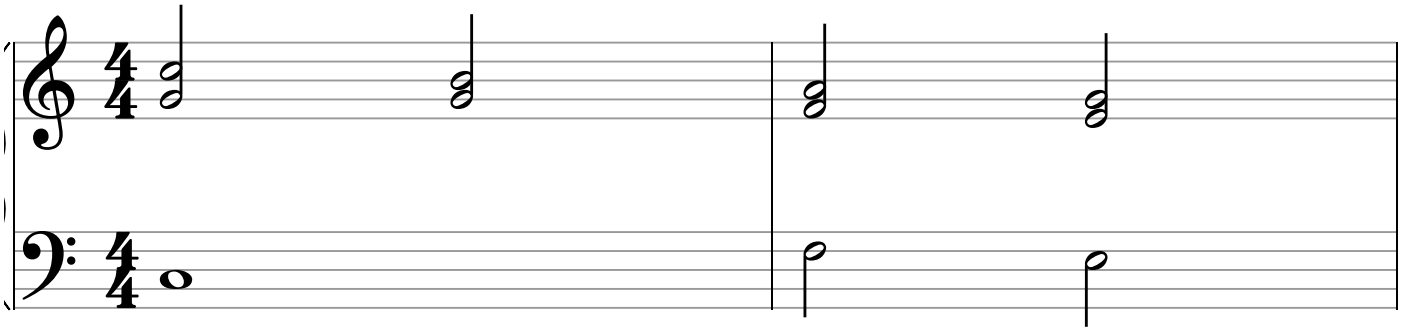
Separate melody, inner support and bass in your listening.

Hear three layers at once

Think of a hymn texture as several singers. First sing the melody while playing the bass. Then sing an inner line by itself. Finally restore the written chords, keeping the melody most present, the bass clear and the inner notes lighter. Balance is a listening task; pressing every chord tone with identical force can bury the tune.

Practise · Melody above paired notes

Play only the top notes once. Restore the lower right-hand notes softly.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Bass direction

Hear the bass as a line moving independently beneath the melody.

Practise independently

Record a short phrase. Can you hum the melody easily and still follow the bass? Repeat with the inner notes quieter, without slowing their attacks.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

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5. Design a useful practice session

Balance technical repair, reading and an uninterrupted performance.

Design a useful practice session

Use three modes deliberately. In repair mode, stop and inspect a small passage. In reading mode, choose manageable unfamiliar music and preserve the pulse. In performance mode, continue to the next landmark after an error. A useful twenty-minute session might contain four minutes of movement, eight of focused repair, four of reading and four of a complete hymn. Adjust the proportions to your actual difficulty.

Practise · A small repair window

Loop the middle bar, then practise all three bars as a sentence.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · A fresh entry

Start on this dominant harmony without playing the earlier phrase.

Practise independently

Choose a repair tempo, a specific success criterion and a stopping point before practising. Finish by playing one complete musical phrase, then note what tomorrow needs.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

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6. Abide with Me: three listening layers

Keep a clear melody above light inner support and a directed bass. Start dry, then add only enough pedal to connect the phrase.

Prepare the score

Keep a clear melody above light inner support and a directed bass. Start dry, then add only enough pedal to connect the phrase.

This is a melody-led piano reduction: supporting tones change with the melody. Source inner voices may be moved by octaves or rearticulated; study their original rhythms using the source score.

Preview the key, meter, pickup and ending. Prepare a stable fingering before adding speed.

Practise · Right hand: voice the melody

Read the upper line first. Where there are two notes, keep the top voice clearer. Release unnecessary pressure.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Left hand: shape the support

Count aloud and play softly. Move the arm between positions; do not hold a wide stretch.

Practise · Join the opening

Keep a clear melody above light inner support and a directed bass. Start dry, then add only enough pedal to connect the phrase.

Practise · Abide with Me: three listening layers

Keep a clear melody above light inner support and a directed bass. Start dry, then add only enough pedal to connect the phrase.

Make your own musical decision

Record a phrase. Identify the melody, inner support and bass separately, then make one balance change.

Practise the alternative at your piano, then return to the written reference if using the app’s pitch check. Record yourself if possible and describe one audible improvement.

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7. Jesus, the Very Thought of Thee: read ahead

Preview each phrase in G major. Read the top line and bass first, then prepare the paired supporting notes without stopping the pulse.

Prepare the score

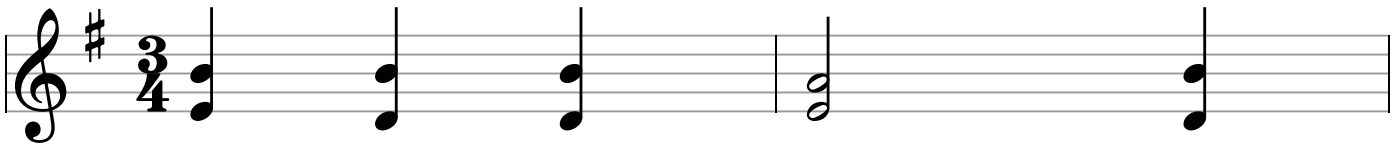
Preview each phrase in G major. Read the top line and bass first, then prepare the paired supporting notes without stopping the pulse.

This is a melody-led piano reduction: supporting tones change with the melody. Source inner voices may be moved by octaves or rearticulated; study their original rhythms using the source score.

Preview the key, meter, pickup and ending. Prepare a stable fingering before adding speed.

Practise · Right hand: voice the melody

Read the upper line first. Where there are two notes, keep the top voice clearer. Release unnecessary pressure.



Opening example · 3/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Left hand: shape the support

Count aloud and play softly. Move the arm between positions; do not hold a wide stretch.

Practise · Join the opening

Preview each phrase in G major. Read the top line and bass first, then prepare the paired supporting notes without stopping the pulse.

Practise · Jesus, the Very Thought of Thee: read ahead

Preview each phrase in G major. Read the top line and bass first, then prepare the paired supporting notes without stopping the pulse.

Make your own musical decision

Choose three phrase entries and begin directly from each without a run-up.

Practise the alternative at your piano, then return to the written reference if using the app’s pitch check. Record yourself if possible and describe one audible improvement.

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8. Holy, Holy, Holy: a clear chorale

Show a continuous pulse, a clear upper voice, planned movement and a calm final release.

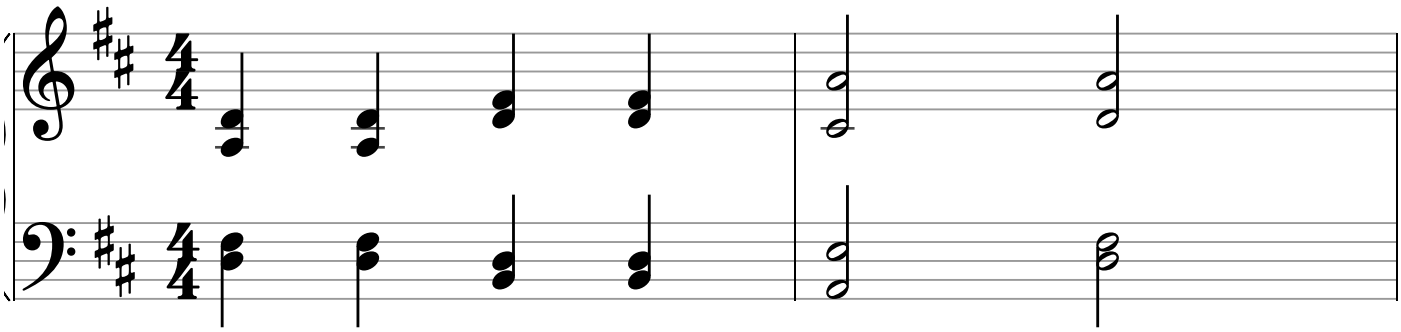
Prepare a complete performance

Show a continuous pulse, a clear upper voice, planned movement and a calm final release.

Choose a tempo at which you can finish comfortably. Mark three restart points, rehearse the opening and ending, then play without stopping. Afterwards assess pulse, clarity, phrasing, balance and recovery. Completion records a reference play-through, not a graded qualification or approval of an improvised arrangement.

Practise · Dress rehearsal: Holy, Holy, Holy

Show a continuous pulse, a clear upper voice, planned movement and a calm final release.



Opening example · 4/4 · D · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Your recital

Show a continuous pulse, a clear upper voice, planned movement and a calm final release.

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9. Jesus, the Very Thought of Thee: a clear chorale

Read ahead in G major, keep the upper voice clear and play the complete hymn with planned movement, a steady pulse and a deliberate ending.

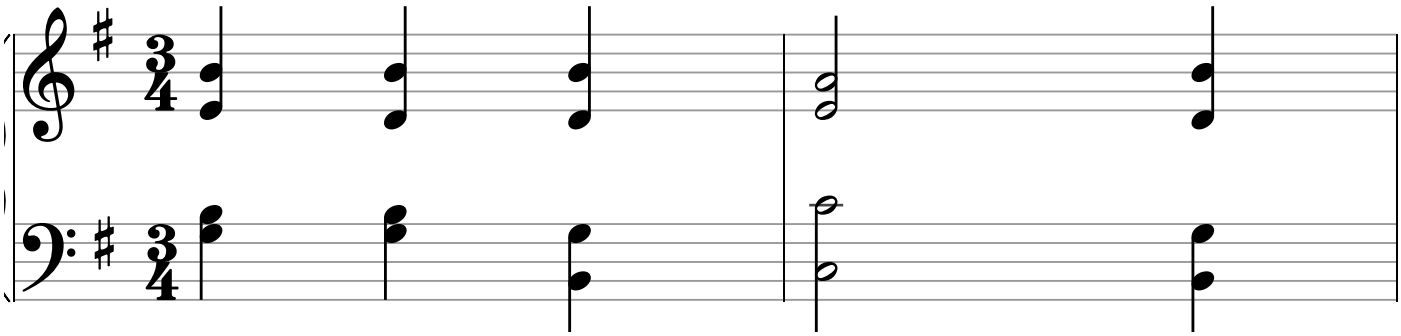
Prepare a complete performance

Read ahead in G major, keep the upper voice clear and play the complete hymn with planned movement, a steady pulse and a deliberate ending.

Choose a tempo at which you can finish comfortably. Mark three restart points, rehearse the opening and ending, then play without stopping. Afterwards assess pulse, clarity, phrasing, balance and recovery. Completion records a reference play-through, not a graded qualification or approval of an improvised arrangement.

Practise · Dress rehearsal: Jesus, the Very Thought of Thee

Read ahead in G major, keep the upper voice clear and play the complete hymn with planned movement, a steady pulse and a deliberate ending.



Opening example · 3/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Your recital

Read ahead in G major, keep the upper voice clear and play the complete hymn with planned movement, a steady pulse and a deliberate ending.

Can I do this independently?

Try these at your piano with hints and note labels turned off. Tick a box when you can do it comfortably; return to the matching lesson when you need a reminder.

- ☐ Assess reading, pulse, voicing and comfortable movement.
- ☐ Choose a repair that addresses the cause of a mistake.
- ☐ Move toward a destination while releasing unnecessary tension.
- ☐ Separate melody, inner support and bass in your listening.
- ☐ Balance technical repair, reading and an uninterrupted performance.
- ☐ Perform my chosen recital with its stated musical goals, clear voicing, reliable pulse, comfortable movement and a deliberate ending.

My next practice goal

What sounded better? What still needs work?
